THE WEBER COUNTY HIVE

How to Research Your Candidates

Where the records are, how to open them, and what to look for

Oct. 17, 2026 · Weber County · Public records only, no endorsements

Every candidate has already filed records about themselves.

Almost nobody reads them.

Who pays
Campaign money reports

What they own
Conflict-of-interest forms

What they did
Bills, votes and minutes

Many choices are made before November

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Weber County races on the 2026 ballot with only one candidate

Commission Seat B · Assessor · Attorney · Clerk/Auditor · Sheriff

Those were settled at the convention and the June primary. Research matters most early, and it still matters for the person who will hold the office.

Source: Weber County 2026 general election ballot and Lt. Governor's certification (Aug. 28, 2026), as listed in the Hive's Weber County voter guide

Ground rules before you start

Records, not rumors

A Facebook post tells you where to look, not what is true.

Write down where you found it

Save the link, the report's name and the date.

Not found is not "not there"

Say where you looked. A missing record proves nothing.

Look at the actual page

A scanned form read by a computer can look blank when it isn't.

Plain, neutral words

"Reported," "listed," "did not list." Leave verdicts to judges.

Same test for everyone

Every candidate, every party, checked the same way.

Seven steps, about 30 minutes a candidate

1 See your own ballot

2 Find where they file

3 Read the conflict-of-interest form

4 Check it against the business registry

5 Follow the money

6 Look behind the PACs

7 Check the record

Every site is free. Every step is in the take-home guide, with the links.

STEP 1

See your own ballot

vote.utah.gov

1. Click "Learn about candidates & issues"
2. Type your home address
3. Write down every race and every name

Why start here

Weber County is split across several House districts and two congressional districts. Your neighbor's ballot may not match yours.

Also on vote.utah.gov: ballot tracking, judges on the ballot, and the voter pamphlet for Amendments A and B

STEP 2

The office decides where the records are

Office on your ballot	Where they file
Utah House, Utah Senate, State School Board	disclosures.utah.gov
County Commission, Attorney, Clerk, Sheriff, Assessor	weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures
Ogden and Weber school boards	weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures
U.S. House	fec.gov
City council and mayor (odd years)	Your city recorder

STEP 3

Read the conflict-of-interest form

What the state form asks

- Employer and job
- Businesses they own or run
- Income sources of $5,000 or more
- Stocks and bonds of $5,000 or more
- Board seats, paid or unpaid
- Spouse's employer

Weber County example

Rep. Katy Hall's **January 2026** form listed her company, Tava Town LLC.

Her **July 2026** form answered "n/a" on owned businesses.

Putting two forms side by side is how that showed up.

Find it: disclosures.utah.gov → Search by Name. Source for example: Hall's filed forms, as reported in the Hive's HD-11 case file

STEP 4

Check the form against the business registry

businessregistration.utah.gov

Search a person: Registered Principal Search shows every company where they're an officer, manager, director or agent.

Search a company: open it, then click "Access Principal Information."

Weber County example

For SD-5 candidate Jill Koford, the registry shows three roles not on her form: two boards and an LLC.

Common names bring up strangers. Match the middle initial and address.

Source for example: Utah Division of Corporations records and Koford's Jan. 10, 2026 form, as reported in the Hive's SD-5 case file

BIG TIP

OpenCorporates: companies outside Utah

opencorporates.com

One search across 140+ government registries. Many vendors and developers are registered in Delaware, Nevada or Wyoming, not Utah.

Officers searches a person's name across every registry at once.

Then cite the state

OpenCorporates copies government records. Click through to the state's own registry page, and cite that.

Use it when a company on a form or donor list doesn't show up in businessregistration.utah.gov

STEP 5

Follow the money

disclosures.utah.gov

One candidate: Search by Name → open their folder → open each report.

Everyone at once: Advanced Search → pick Entity Type and Report Year → Find → click the year under "Download Data by Year."

County candidates: weberelections.gov/financialdisclosures. Most are scanned PDFs.

What to look at

- People or organizations?
- Donors who live in the district
- Timing of big gifts
- Late, deleted, amended entries
- Candidate's own money
- Who gets paid

THE 31-DAY CHECK

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days between when a gift was received and when it first appeared

HD-7: a $500 gift to Rep. Ryan Wilcox dated July 8, 2026 first appears in his filings on Sept. 30. Utah requires each contribution to be reported within 31 days.

Source: Wilcox's own filings on disclosures.utah.gov, as reported in the Hive's HD-7 case file · 31-day rule: disclosures.utah.gov home page

STEP 6

Look behind the PACs

A PAC's name says nothing about who is behind it. Every PAC files its own reports on disclosures.utah.gov: officers, donors, and who it gives to.

House Speaker Leadership PAC

UHREC

NUPAC

Same treasurer on all three: Kyle Palmer. His firm, Irish Elk LLC, is paid by these PACs and by candidates.

Source: PAC filings on disclosures.utah.gov, as reported in the Hive's Weber County voter guide. Lobbyists: lobbyist.utah.gov

BIG TIP

The Meta Ad Library: see the ads and who paid

facebook.com/ads/library

1. Location: United States
2. Category: Issues, elections or politics
3. Search a candidate, PAC or keyword
4. Filters → show active and inactive ads

Each political ad shows

- "Paid for by"
- Spending and views, as ranges
- Who saw it: age, gender, state
- Dates it ran

Spending by state: the Ad Library Report shows the top advertisers in Utah. Not all are political, so check each name.

Political ads stay in the library for seven years. Facebook and Instagram only; TV, radio and mail aren't in it.

STEP 7

Check the record, not the promise

le.utah.gov

Find your legislators. Open a bill to see every version and every vote. Compare the first version with the one that passed.

utah.gov/pmn

Agendas and minutes for cities, counties, school boards and districts. Who voted how, and who disclosed a conflict.

Their own words

Campaign site, interviews, forums. Treat each claim as a claim until it matches a bill, vote or minutes.

BIG TIP

The Wayback Machine: see what a page used to say

web.archive.org

1. Paste the page's address
2. Pick a year, then a marked day
3. Write down the date on the copy

Save Page Now keeps a dated copy of a page before it changes.

Example

Election Hive's website once ran a bio page for Dan Hemmert, now MIDA's executive director.

The page has since been taken down. The saved copy still shows it.

Not every page was saved. No copy doesn't mean the page never existed.

Federal sites to search

Site	What it shows
fec.gov	Money in races for Congress, including super PACs
disclosures-clerk.house.gov	House members' financial disclosures and stock trades
efdsearch.senate.gov	Senators' and Senate candidates' disclosures
usaspending.gov	Federal contracts, grants and loans, by who got them
IRS Tax Exempt Search	Whether a nonprofit is exempt, and its Form 990s

Use them together: a company that gives to a candidate may also get federal money. A nonprofit's 990 lists its officers and pay.

Common traps

What you see	What it may really mean
A blank-looking form	A scanned page. Read it with your eyes.
"Campaign Expense"	The public report shows the category; a typed description may not show.
A donor with the same name	Maybe a stranger. Match address and middle initial.
"Roost," "Roost Co."	One vendor can be filed several ways. Search the short name.
Dates a day apart	Normal filing lag between giver and receiver.
An unknown gift of $50 or less	Allowed by Utah Code 20A-11-301.

One scale for everyone

A	Goes well beyond what the law requires
B	Goes beyond the requirement
C	Meets the law, and no more
D	There, but vague, lumped together or late
F	Required information missing

Five questions

Power · Transparency · Financial accountability · Environmental impact · Community impact

Campaign money

Graded on the share from individual people: A = 90%+, B = 67–89%, C = 34–66%, D = 10–33%, F = under 10%.

Filing deadlines: when the next report is due

State candidates and PACs

Report	Due
September 30th	Sept. 30
General	Oct. 27
Year End	Jan. 10, 2027

U.S. House (FEC)

Report	Due
October Quarterly	Oct. 15
Pre-General	Oct. 22
Post-General	Dec. 3

Between reports: each gift within **31 days**, or **7 business days** in the 30 days before the election if the race is contested. Filing on the due date is on time.

Sources: Lt. Governor's 2026 Financial Disclosure Deadlines (disclosures.utah.gov/File/308); FEC 2026 reporting dates. Weber County candidates: ask 801-399-8034

Weber County dates

Date	What happens
Oct. 13	Ballots mailed; drop boxes open
Oct. 23, 5 p.m.	Regular voter registration deadline
Oct. 27–30	Early voting, noon–6 p.m., Weber Center basement
Nov. 3	Election Day, 7 a.m.–8 p.m. Fairgrounds Exhibit Hall or Ogden Valley Branch Library

Mailed ballots must be received by 8 p.m. Nov. 3. Close to the deadline, use a drop box.

Source: weberelections.gov and Weber County's Official Public Notice of General Election · Questions: 801-399-8034

Found something? Send it.

webercountyhive@gmail.com

Send the link and the name of the record. Every tip is checked against the records before anything is published.

Take-home guide
Every site, every step, every link

Weber County voter guide
What the records show, race by race

2026 case files
weber-county-hive.github.io/candidates2026